

BAAZ & UDAY JKBOSE

2026 CLASS 11TH



“We’re Not Afraid to Die...
if we Can All Be Together”

LECTURE-04

ENGLISH

HUSSAIN SIR



Topics To Covered

- 1 “We’re Not Afraid to Die...if we Can All Be Together”
- 2 ... **Explanation , Summary**
- 3 ...
- 4 ...

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PROSE – 2

“We’re Not Afraid to Die...
if we can all be together”
(Summary)

Gordon Cook and Alan East

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"We're Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together"

The Dream of Sailing *narrator*

In July 1976, Gordon Cook, his wife Mary, and their two children Jonathan, aged six, and Suzanne, aged seven, set out from Plymouth, England, to duplicate Captain James Cook's famous voyage around the world that had taken place two hundred years earlier. The couple had been preparing for this adventure for sixteen years. They had practiced sailing in the rough waters of Britain, studied navigation, and saved money to build a strong boat. Their boat, named Wavewalker, was professionally built. It was twenty-three metres long, weighed thirty tons, and was designed to withstand rough seas. Their children were excited about the journey, and the family's spirits were high as they began their adventure.



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The Journey to Cape Town

The first part of the journey went smoothly. The family sailed down the west coast of Africa and reached the Cape of Good Hope. From there, they sailed to Cape Town, South Africa. Everything went according to plan, and they felt confident about the voyage. But they knew the most dangerous part still lay ahead—the southern Indian Ocean, which was notorious for its violent weather and huge waves.



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Hiring Extra Crew

To prepare for this rough stretch, Gordon hired two experienced crewmen to help them: Larry Vigil, an American, and Herb Seigler, a Swiss. Both were expert sailors who could handle emergency situations. With their help, the family was ready to face the longest and most dangerous leg of their 105,000-kilometre journey. *part*



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July → start.
December

Christmas at Sea

By December 25, 1976, they were about 3,500 kilometres east of Cape Town. The family celebrated Christmas at sea. Although the weather was turning bad and the waves were growing stronger, their spirits remained cheerful. They did not know that greater trouble was just around the corner.



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The New Year Storm

1976-1977

On January 2, 1977, their worst fears came true. For seven days they had been facing terrible weather, but now the sea turned into a wild monster. Waves rose twice as high as their ship, and the wind roared at 130 kilometres per hour. They were all exhausted after continuously battling the storm, but the situation was still getting worse.



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The Giant Wave

By the evening of January 2, it seemed that the storm was weakening. At six o’clock, the sea looked calmer. But an hour later, Gordon noticed something terrifying—a gigantic wave unlike anything he had ever seen before. It looked like a black mountain of water, towering over them and rushing towards the boat. Their Wavewalker seemed like a small toy in front of it.



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The Wave Strikes

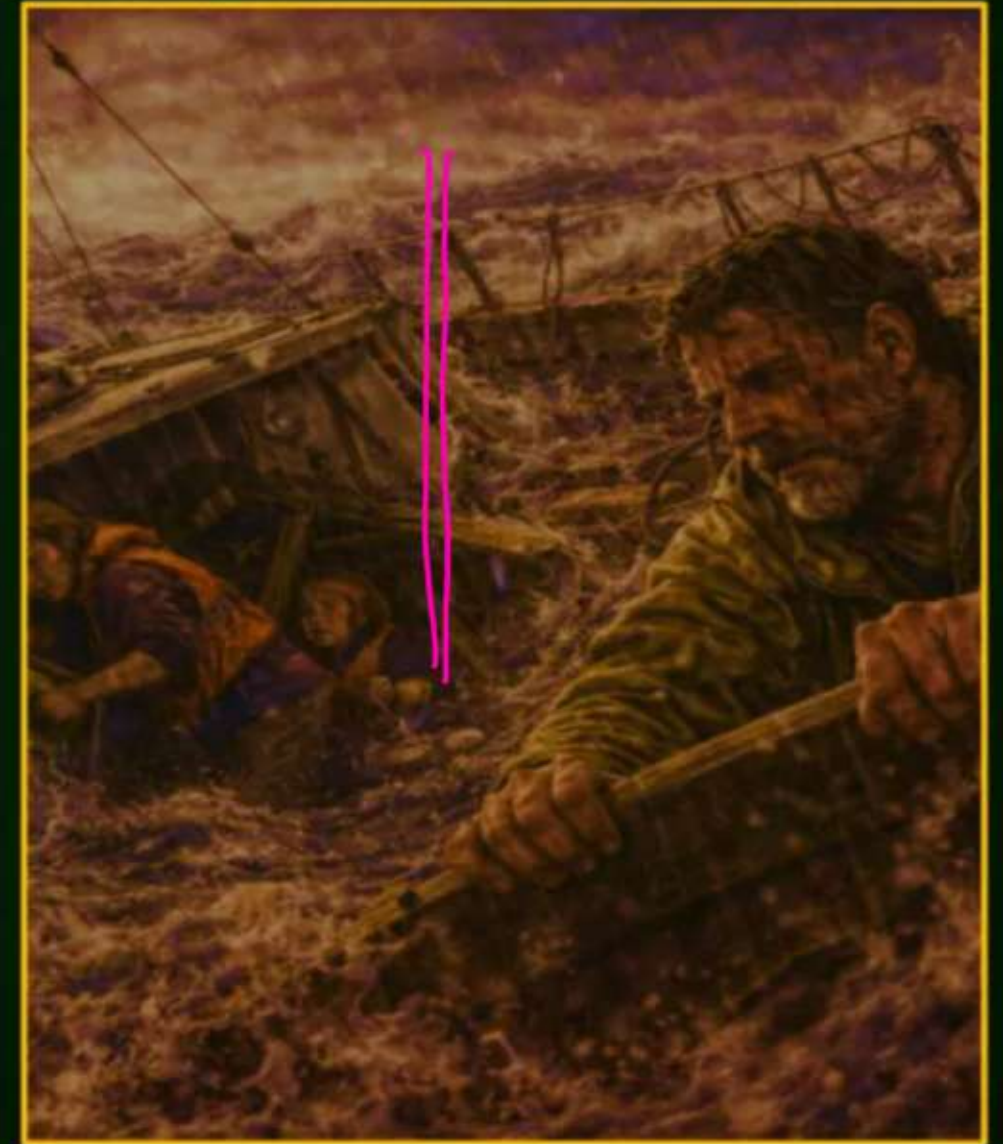
Gordon acted quickly. He slowed the boat, checked all ropes, and told everyone to wear life jackets and tie themselves with lifelines for safety. Then he returned to the wheel. Suddenly, the huge wave crashed down on them. The boat was lifted high into the air, then thrown violently down. Gordon was hurled across the deck, his ribs cracked, and his head was badly hurt. He was thrown overboard into the sea. For a moment, he thought it was the end. But another wave pushed him back towards the boat, and he managed to grab the rails and climb back on deck.



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Damage to Wavewalker

The condition of Wavewalker was terrible. The main mast had broken, sails were torn, the side rails were smashed, and water was flooding inside. The steering wheel was useless. Inside the boat, woodwork and equipment were destroyed. Gordon himself was badly injured with a swollen head, broken ribs, and a bleeding mouth, but he ignored the pain. His only focus was on saving his family and the boat.



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Struggling Through the Night

For the next fifteen hours, everyone worked tirelessly. Larry and Herb pumped water continuously, Mary helped them, and Gordon tried to make temporary repairs. The electric pump had failed because of short-circuiting, so they had to pump water by hand. Water kept rushing in, and it seemed almost impossible to save the boat. But no one gave up, and the fight continued all through the night of January 2 and into January 3.



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Children Show Courage

During this desperate time, Gordon went to check on his children. Suzanne had been badly injured. She had a deep cut on her head, two black eyes, and a swollen face. Later she needed six stitches. Yet she did not complain. She whispered to her father, “I don’t want to worry you when you are trying to save us all.” Jonathan, only six years old, said something even more inspiring: “Daddy, we aren’t afraid to die... if we can all be together.” These brave words filled Gordon with strength and determination to go on.



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Temporary Repairs

Using canvas, plastic sheets, and spare ropes, Gordon managed to cover the broken areas of the boat. This slowed the flooding and gradually reduced the water level inside. The storm continued for another thirty-six hours, but thanks to these repairs, the Wavewalker stayed afloat.



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Searching for Land

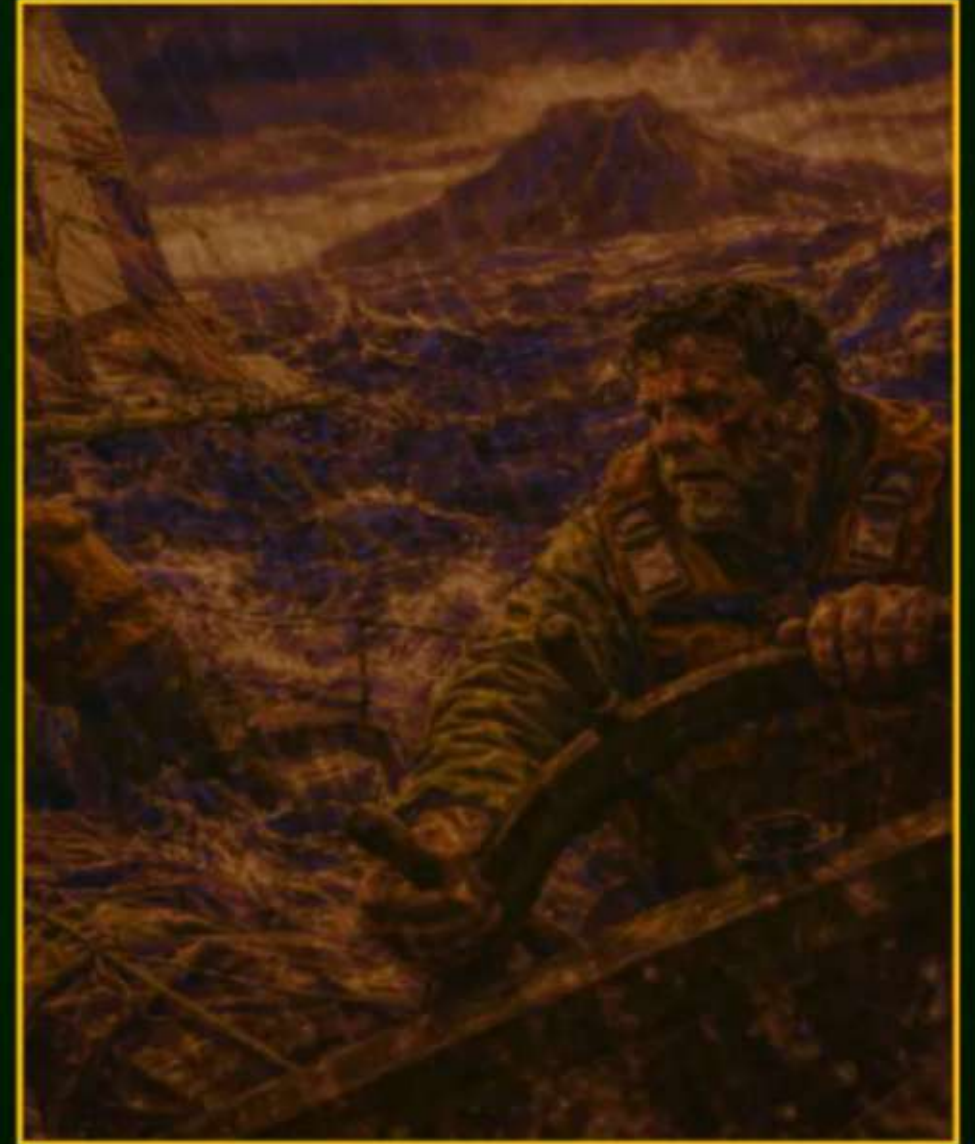
Now Gordon had to think of where to go. Checking his charts, he realised that their only hope was to reach Amsterdam Island, a small volcanic island in the southern Indian Ocean belonging to the French. Another nearby island was Île de St. Paul, but Amsterdam was closer. It was about sixty-five kilometres away, but with their damaged boat, even this short distance was a great challenge.



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Sailing Towards Amsterdam Island

On January 4 and 5, the crew struggled towards Amsterdam Island. The compass was damaged, so navigation was uncertain. Still, Gordon managed rough calculations and steered as best as he could. The patched sails carried them slowly. The waves were still high and violent, and each one threatened to sink them. Everyone was weak, bruised, and hungry, but they held on with courage.



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Land at Last

On January 6, 1977, they finally saw Amsterdam Island in the distance. The sight of land filled them with joy and relief. They cried tears of happiness. After endless struggle, they reached the shore safely.



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Safe on Amsterdam Island

Amsterdam Island had only twenty-eight inhabitants, mostly French scientists and workers. They welcomed the family warmly, gave them food, shelter, and medical care. Suzanne’s wounds were stitched properly, and the family could finally rest after their terrifying ordeal.



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The Lesson of Courage

This experience taught Gordon that courage, determination, and unity are the most powerful forces in life. His wife and crew had worked with great strength, but above all, it was his children’s bravery that gave him the will to fight. Suzanne endured her pain silently, and Jonathan’s words, “We aren’t afraid to die if we can all be together,” became the inspiration that carried them through the storm. The story shows that when people stand together with hope and courage, even the fiercest storms can be overcome.



QUESTION

List the steps taken by the captain

- (i) to protect the ship when rough weather began.
- (ii) to check the flooding of the water in the ship.

ANSWER:

- (i) To protect the ship when rough weather began, the captain planned to slow the ship down. The storm jib was dropped and the mooring rope which was heavy was lashed in a loop over the stem. Everything was double-fastened and they went through the life-raft drill.
- (ii) Herb and Larry started to pump the water out. The canvas was stretched by the captain and the waterproof hatch covers were secured across the gaping holes. When the electric pump short circuited and two hand pumps were blocked, he noticed another electric pump and started it by connecting it to an earth pipe.

QUESTION

Describe the mental condition of the voyagers on 4th and 5th January.

ANSWER:

On 4th January, after pumping out water continuously for 36 hours, the voyagers felt relieved. They consumed their first meal in two days. But their break was short-lived. On 5th January, they faced a dangerous situation. The fear of death appeared huge and they underwent great mental stress.

QUESTION



Describe the shifts in the narration of the events as indicated in the three sections of the text. Give a subtitle to each section.

ANSWER:

The first section explains a peaceful journey from Plymouth in England to 3500 km east of Cape Town in Africa. The narrator is fully confident and relaxed. Then they faced huge waves as the weather deteriorated. To save themselves, they took precautionary measures and struggled with the disaster. The narration becomes grim, but exudes confidence and illustrates their fighting spirit and strong will power. The Wave-walker rode out of the storm by 6th January morning, and by evening, they sighted the Ile Amsterdam Island. Now the narrator is relaxed. Relief, joy and confidence are apparent.

QUESTION



What difference did you notice between the reaction of the adults and the children when faced with danger?

ANSWER:

There are lots of differences in the way the children and adults reacted when faced with danger. The adults initially felt the stress of the situation. But they soon garnered strength and prepared themselves to face it. When the rough weather began, enough precautions were taken to protect the ship. Everyone was equipped with water-proof clothes, lifelines and life jackets. Herb and Larry worked optimistically and cheerfully for three continuous days to pump the water out from the ship. The narrator at the wheel was replaced by Mary who steered the ship when the deck was smashed. She served them meals after a struggle of two days against all odds. As a captain, the narrator performed his role with determination, courage, responsibility and resourcefulness. He undertook the repair work by providing apparatus and giving the directions which were required to protect the ship. He helped in steering the ship towards the island. The children suffered patiently and silently. Sue, with her troubles, did not bother her father. Jon behaved courageously and was not scared to die if everyone perished together.

Resourcefulness. He undertook the repair work by providing apparatus and giving the directions which were required to protect the ship. He helped in steering the ship towards the island. The children suffered patiently and silently. Sue, with her troubles, did not bother her father. Jon behaved courageously and was not scared to die if everyone perished together.

QUESTION



How does the story suggest that optimism helps to endure "the direst stress"?

ANSWER:

The story suggests that optimism helps to endure "the direst stress". The behaviour of four adults throughout the crisis bears it out. Herb Seigler and Larry Vigil were the two crewmen. As the deck was smashed by the huge waves, water entered the ship from the openings and holes. From the evening of 2nd January, Herb and Larry started to pump out water. They worked feverishly, excitedly and continuously for about 36 hours. As a result of pumping continuously, they reached the last few centimeters of water on 4th January. They stayed optimistic and cheerful while facing dangerous situations. The narrator did not lose his presence of mind, hope or courage while facing problems. He was not worried about the equipment loss and used whatever was present there. His practical knowledge and self-confidence helped them steer out of the storm and reach the Ile Amsterdam Island. In those difficult hours, Mary remained at the wheel. She did not lose courage or hope either.

QUESTION



What lessons do we learn from such hazardous experiences when we are face-to-face with death?

ANSWER:

Hazardous experiences bring us face-to-face with death and impart a few crucial lessons. Our life is not always a bed of roses. We must respond to risks and danger with fortitude and patience. The real test of character is adversity. The purity of gold is decided by putting it on fire. So, hazardous experiences of life bring the best out of us. Before death, cowards die many times. Negative feelings like fear lead to inactivity and abject surrender to situations. Such soldiers or sailors lose the war against difficulties in life. On the other hand, people with courage, self-confidence, presence of mind and resourcefulness face the dangers bravely and successfully come out of all disasters. Their caring and sharing attitude inspires others to face difficult situations boldly and steer through them with fortitude.

QUESTION



Why do you think people undertake such adventurous expeditions in spite of the risks involved?

ANSWER:

How

Human beings are adventurous by nature. The higher the risk, the more the thrill. The thrill of exploring lands and discovering the beauty and wealth which lies hidden in far-off lands inspires brave people to even put their lives at stake. Maybe, they value one hour of glory more than an uneventful long life of inactivity and sloth. At times, adventures are risky and prove deadly. The failure of a few people does not discourage true lovers of adventure. They learn lessons from errors and shortcomings of others and make new attempts with greater zeal. The key to an adventurous expedition lies in adapting to the situations and overcoming the problems. The victory of an adventurous expedition brings wealth, fame and glory. History books are full with accounts of well-known explorers such as Vasco da Gama, Columbus, Captain Scott and Captain Cook.

QUESTION

We have come across words like 'gale' and 'storm' in the account. Here are two more words for 'storm': typhoon, cyclone. How many words does your language have for 'storm'?

ANSWER:

The Hindi language has the following words for 'storm': toofan, aandhi, chakravat, and jhanjavat

QUESTION

Here are the terms for different kinds of vessels: yacht, boat, canoe, ship, steamer, schooner. Think of similar terms in your language.

ANSWER:

Similar terms in Hindi for vessels which are used to travel on water are nava, nauka, jahaj, and pot

QUESTION

'Catamaran' is a kind of a boat. Do you know which Indian language this word is derived from? Check the dictionary.

ANSWER:

'Catamaran' is a word derived from Tamil which means 'tied wood'. It is a boat or yacht containing twin hulls in parallel. It is defined as 'a fast sailing boat with two hulls' in the dictionary.

QUESTION

Have you heard any boatmen's songs? What kind of emotions do these songs usually express?

ANSWER:

The boatmen's songs invite other sailors to awaken, arise and come to the sea to explore its wealth. These are inspirational songs that provide moral support to the hard-working boatmen.

Thank
You